



ARCTIC FEVER

ARCTIC FEVER

Image and Narrative
in North Circumpolar Voyaging
of the Long Nineteenth Century

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The Library on Ice: Tracing the Arctic Collections at the Thomas Fisher Rare Book Library

GRANT HURLEY

Building a library collection is a multi-generational enterprise. While an individual can amass a remarkable book collection during a lifetime, the depth and breadth of institutional research collections reflect many decades and even centuries of dedicated effort. Collections are created one book at a time, reviewed and selected by individual librarians in the day-to-day work of responding to the changing needs of researchers, instructors, and the broader publics that libraries serve. These daily evaluative decisions seek to identify if a particular item fits within a larger whole. The ‘larger whole’ is the theory of a collection: the drive to collect within a subject area or discipline to cultivate a record of human memory, and the collecting principles and mandates that give structure to this work. The praxis involves asking: is this specific item worthy to acquire for research, teaching, or outreach? If we seek to be completists in a particular area, does it fill a gap? If it is held already, what level of variation or uniqueness (printing differences, special bindings, association copies, and much more) would merit the acquisition of an additional copy? Perhaps most crucially, can we afford it in terms of material cost, storage space, conservation and preservation requirements, and staff time to catalogue it and make it accessible? Stack together the results of these questions over many years and you have something more than the sum of its parts: a set of materials in conversation with one another

that document human creativity, curiosity, questions, debates, and dialogues across the centuries. But as with any activity that happens over long time-spans, the decisions of those who came before us can be opaque. Why did they start collecting in this subject area? Why were some materials chosen over others? Why did we take *that* collection? New generations of librarians are tasked with continuing the legacies of those that came before them, but also shifting received norms and practices as discourses, methods, and subject interests in scholarship and teaching at their institution change. The work of collections development is overwhelmingly future-facing (What books should we buy? What new research areas or approaches should we respond to?). Rarely do we step back and question the thinking of our forebears. As we prepared the *Arctic Fever* exhibition, curator Mark A. Cheetham asked me a simple question: why does the Thomas Fisher Library have such a rich set of materials documenting the Canadian Arctic? Ironically, the institutional memory of memory institutions can be spotty at times, and I had no answer. Having started my role as Canadiana Librarian at the Fisher Library a year before, I took the presence of these materials in the collections for granted. The remainder of this essay traces the legacies of the Arctic collections in answer to Mark's prompt.

Collections development is the practice of building up a set of library materials to meet the needs of a research community. Rare book libraries have a unique interest in not only the contents of the books on the shelves, but in their contexts: their histories as resonant objects intimately entangled in human lives. Annotated and inscribed books, censored and banned books, and many books for which few copies survive are well-represented among the Fisher Library's collections. After decades or centuries of book-life lived elsewhere, books usually find themselves in a rare book library in one of two ways: purchased from a book dealer or as part of a gift. Purchases are made title-by-title as budgets allow; gifts can be made up of individual items too, but significant collections showing the devotion, expertise, and persistence of private collectors can be composed of hundreds or even thousands of titles. Gifts of large collections often have the result of setting



new collections directions, turning the library overnight into a world-renowned resource for the history of socialism and communism or the works of Lewis Carroll, two such cases that apply to the Thomas Fisher Rare Book Library. When donors desire that their collections continue to expand in their after-lives, subsequent acquisitions seek to match their attention and dedication. The histories of these large, gifted collections can be easily traced. They are often named after the collector and are usually kept as a whole for the devotion they demonstrate and the potential for insights that can be derived not just from each item, but each item in conversation. But libraries themselves can set collections directions, sometimes documented in policies or mandates, which are meant to support communities of interest, often within their local region or at their host institution. The Fisher Library's subject specialities in British literatures and theology, for example, reflect institutional priorities that were established in the earliest years of the Library's

A woman, possibly a maid, stands in the dining room of the Tyrrell family home at 52 Alexander Street in Ottawa, circa 1897. Note the polar bear skin rug and large bookshelf on the right side.

operations. In this way, library collections at academic institutions embed sticky ideologies that cannot be decoupled from their broader institutional environment. Recent efforts to improve the representation of marginalized voices among these collections are a direct attempt to counter the weight of these historical priorities. The Arctic collections at Fisher Library are an excellent case study in these complex histories.

The Department of Rare Books and Special Collections was established at the University of Toronto Library in 1955 by Chief Librarian Robert H. Blackburn. Led by Marion Brown, the new unit was first tasked with properly accounting for the materials in the so-called 'Art Cupboard', a collection of books and manuscripts deemed special or significant that had been gathering since 1890, when the library was destroyed by a catastrophic fire at University College. A large collection of works of Anglo-Irish literature donated by Mathematics professor Alfred Tennyson De Lury occupied the first batch of cataloging work for the new department. But Arctic themes were in the air. Two years earlier, renowned Canadian bibliographer Marie Tremain led the publication of the first three volumes of the eventual 16-volume *Arctic Bibliography*. Tremain had previously published a bibliography of Canadiana at the Toronto Public Library (1934), and in 1952, a bibliography of Canadian imprints to 1800 that remains a core reference work in Canadian book history. Before the internet (and even since), printed bibliographies such as these were the primary way that knowledge about extant texts on a subject could be circulated among specialists and researchers, as well as librarians invested in building specialized or comprehensive collections. Early additions to the Rare Books and Special Collections department from the Art Cupboard included items that would have been identified using Tremain's bibliographies of Canadiana,¹ and it is likely that Brown and her staff were aware of the *Arctic Bibliography*.

The *Arctic Bibliography* itself was at the centre of post-World War II interest in the Arctic as both political space and site for resource extraction. The bibliography was among the first publishing projects of the Arctic Institute of North America, a binational research organization established

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The J. B. Tyrrell Library
Bequeathed to the
University of Toronto Library
by
Joseph Burr Tyrrell
A.A., F.R.S., F.R.S.C.,
F.G.S., F.G.S.A.
Graduate of the University of Toronto,
and eminent Canadian geologist,
explorer, and scholar

in 1944 and funded by a mix of government grants and private business. Initially created with the aim of investigating how ‘Canada could increase her administrative, scientific, and technical competence in the Arctic to match that of other Arctic nations, such as the Soviet Union’, the Institute set up a program of research grounded in the establishment of their own polar library.² The library was itself created from the private collection of Philip Smith, head of the Alaskan Division of the United States Geological Survey.³ The *Arctic Bibliography* project was initiated in 1947 to create the most comprehensive resource possible documenting the existing scientific and travel literature of the Arctic, with Tremaine relocating to Washington to coordinate this massive project using the Library of Congress as a key resource.⁴ The first volumes of the *Arctic Bibliography* bear the subtitle ‘prepared for and in coordination with the Department of Defense’, which places Tremaine’s work firmly within the space of Cold War territorial anxieties about Soviet threats to North American Arctic sovereignty and knits together government investment in scientific research with military defense.⁵

It is within this climate that the Fisher Library’s speciality in Arctic materials was established. Two gifts, one in 1957 and the other in 2002, bookend nearly seventy years of dedicated collecting in the subject area. In November 1957, Blackburn coordinated the bequest of Joseph Burr Tyrrell’s large collection of archival materials and personal book collection. Tyrrell (1858–1957) is best remembered as the discoverer of the *Albertosaurus* dinosaur in Canada, but his archives primarily document his career as a surveyor for the Geological Survey of Canada, including expeditions to the Barren Grounds region in present-day Nunavut and the Northwest Territories in 1893 and 1894. These expeditions were for the purpose of surveying and mapping territory unknown to settlers and identifying hoped-for rich mineral resources, both crucial to the colonial project of Canadian territorial expansion and economic exploitation of lands then still unceded by treaty.⁶ Tyrrell later became a mining consultant in the Yukon during the Klondike gold rush, which led to a subsequent role as President of the Kirkland Lake Gold Mines from 1922–1955. Described by the Canadian Mining Hall of Fame as having

‘conquered the Canadian North’,⁷ Tyrrell also was clearly interested in the history of travel through the region, editing editions of writings by travellers Samuel Hearne (1911) and David Thompson (1916) for The Champlain Society.

A December 3, 1957, letter in the internal collections documentation files of the Fisher Library from Blackburn to Tyrrell’s son Thomas notes, ‘I was out at the farm today and brought away all the books without attempting to sort them there’. Blackburn also includes a copy of the bookplate that would later be pasted into Tyrrell’s volumes, which identifies the books as part of the ‘J.B. Tyrrell Library’. Accession card catalogue entries indicate that Tyrrell’s books began to be accessioned and catalogued into the collections in November 1957 and throughout 1958, meaning that Blackburn must have made several trips to pack up the collection. Unfortunately, records do not exist that document the total size of the book collection when it was received. Provenance information was not included in early library card catalogues due to space restrictions on the traditional five by seven-inch card, and therefore did not make it into library databases, making it impossible to reconstruct the full extent of Tyrrell’s library without reviewing thousands of cards. However, Tyrrell’s manuscript collection is documented via a finding aid listing the contents of 294 boxes.⁸ A brief survey of accession records shows a diverse set of books not entirely devoted to northern topics, from University of Toronto history to Joel Chandler Harris’ *Uncle Remus* tales, and a copy of a 1806 bible with a note in the back saying it was purchased ‘in 1819 for the price of a cow’.⁹ While most of the materials do document Arctic and Canadian subjects, the spread of the collection may explain why Tyrrell’s books were catalogued into the general collections of the rare book library, rather than being retained as a distinct unit.

Tyrrell’s books were recognized as a cornerstone of Arctic Canadiana in the Department of Rare Books and Special Collections. In June 1971, the Department held a small exhibition of materials related to the Northwest Passage and Barren Lands, until now, the Department’s first and only exhibition specifically devoted to a northern topic.¹⁰ Of the restrained group of eight titles on display, six were from Tyrrell’s collection, including one report

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from the archival collection. Two other titles from the seventeenth century had been purchased in 1966 and 1968, respectively: Luke Fox's *North-West Fox* (1635) and Thomas James's *The Strange and Dangerous Voyage of Captaine Thomas James* (1633), indicating efforts in the early years to supplement Tyrrell's gift with earlier works on Arctic topics. As part of research efforts for this essay, myself and research assistants Ivana Dizdar and Julie-Ann Mercer inspected one hundred books, including those in use in the *Arctic Fever* exhibition. Of this sample, forty-one were acquired from the library via gifts and the remaining fifty-nine by purchase or transfer from other sites at the University of Toronto Libraries, indicating that Tyrrell's collection clearly set a precedent that was followed by dedicated title-by-title collections building over the years.

It was not until 2002 that a second major donation continued Tyrrell's legacy: 217 books previously owned by John Tuzo Wilson (1908–1993) were gifted to the library from Wilson's daughter Patricia Proctor (1944–2019). Wilson is remembered as the core contributor to the theory of plate tectonics, and Proctor was herself an accomplished expert in Chinese ceramics at the Royal Ontario Museum. Tyrrell and Wilson shared much in common: both obtained degrees from the University of Toronto; both worked for the Geological Survey of Canada in surveying areas of northern Canada; and both authored publications on Samuel Hearne.¹¹ The books they collected are very similar in subject and topic with a heavy emphasis on government reports and travel narratives, including the many books and reports relating to searches for the missing John Franklin, key to *Arctic Fever*. Though Tyrrell's collecting sources and habits are unknown, Wilson described his book collecting in an unpublished memoir where he relates that during his master's degree in Geology at Cambridge University in 1930–1932, his tutor James Mann Wordie (1889–1962) advised him to collect books about polar regions, evidently with the goal of both producing a well-read scholar and because of their potential to accrue financial value.¹² Wordie himself is a noted figure in polar travel, having served as geologist for Ernest Shackleton's gruelling 1914 Imperial Trans-Antarctic Expedition and on several subsequent

Arctic trips. Wilson followed up on this advice during the Second World War, when 'Books had been accounted a poor risk in the Blitz and prices had plummeted'.¹³ With his wife Isabel, 'we passed hour after quiet hour in the stacks of Maggs, of Francis Edwards, of the Museum Bookshelf, or cruising up and down the Tottenham Court Road hanging over the tables of old books ranged along the street, tracking down the first editions of Samuel Hearne and of the multitudinous annals stemming from the Franklin Search'.¹⁴ The Canadian Army obligingly shipped his new purchases back home to Canada. Tuzo's daughter Susan Wilson recalls the books on display with pride in the family's living room and being brought out to guests who showed an interest in them, but it is unclear to what extent Wilson continued collecting after the War.¹⁵ Wilson's collection includes a 1716 work of natural history, *Rariora musei Besleriani quae*, but most date to the nineteenth century, such as a signed presentation copy of John Franklin's *Narrative of a Journey to the Shores of the Polar Sea* (1823) and a copy of Leopold McClintock's *The Voyage of the 'Fox' in the Arctic Seas* (1859) inscribed by Lady Jane Franklin. Collecting a generation earlier, Tyrrell evidently had access to older books and his collection includes earlier works such as *Report Relating to the Finding of a North-West Passage* (1742).

Unlike Tyrrell, Wilson's life was shaped by international rather than national currents of research and politics surrounding the Arctic. In 1946, as head of Operations Research for the Canadian Army, he was involved in the planning and execution of Operation Musk Ox, a military exercise intended to test new technologies such as the snowmobile (nicknamed the 'Penguin') and military operations in the Canadian North. Forty-eight men and eleven 'Penguins' and other vehicles began their journey at Churchill, Manitoba in February 1946, travelling north to Cambridge Bay in Nunavut, and then again southwards to Edmonton, ending with a victory parade in that city on 6 May 1946. While Wilson insisted that the expedition was to teach Canadians how to 'operate in our own country', the press interpreted the event as a demonstration of Canada's military prowess in the face of fears of possible Russian overland invasion from the north.¹⁶ As Wilson transitioned

to civilian life, he also helped found the Arctic Institute of North America, acting as Chairman of its Board of Governors in 1947.¹⁷

The Arctic has long been an area of interest among private book collectors. Collecting is a form of armchair travel, the appeal seemingly in owning and reading objects proximate to the thrilling era of settler-driven Arctic enthusiasm. The Fisher Library's two key donors of Arctic materials are unique in that both visited and worked on the lands that their collections document. Their drive to collect books on the Arctic seems to have been grounded in the careful study of those fellow travellers who came before them. But despite having had actual boots on permafrost, both remained just that: travellers in contrast to the many Indigenous communities who call the Arctic their home and know it intimately. One of the ironies of the frequent insistence in writings about Tyrrell 'exploring' lands 'previously unknown' is the large number of people he encountered along the way.¹⁸ Both Tyrrell and Wilson relied heavily on Inuit interpreters, informants, and guides during their travels, and while they each expressed admiration for the Inuit, both were involved in efforts that would have profoundly negative effects on Inuit life. Indeed, while Wilson reportedly felt 'pangs of regret' about the potential impacts of opening up the North on the Inuit, he kept these 'reservations about developing the North to himself'.¹⁹ Similarly, projects like the *Arctic Bibliography* continued centuries-long views of Inuit communities as the subject of research and unfortunate victims of scientific progress, rather than sovereign peoples and rich knowledge keepers in their own right. Tremaine summarized prevailing attitudes towards the Inuit succinctly in her introduction, noting in the long tradition of salvage ethnography that the Inuit were a 'but recently primitive' group about to be impacted by a 'technically advanced civilization', a subject that would serve as a useful 'laboratory situation for sociological study'.²⁰ This blinkered perspective, widely shared in Canada until quite recently, meant resulting Arctic collections were not truly representative of the lands and its people. The circumpolar scope of the *Arctic Fever* exhibition has broadened the boundaries of our collecting priorities beyond the 'Canadian North' towards

a more transnational approach, recognizing that for Indigenous groups and others living across the Arctic, the region has shared ecologies, linked cultures and languages, and histories that trouble nationalist frames. For example, bringing in materials representing nineteenth and early twentieth-century Sámi perspectives and materials from Kalaallit Nunaat in print puts Indigenous Arctic knowledge and histories about their homelands in a remarkable conversation.²¹

Though the Fisher Library has wonderful examples of texts authored by Inuit storytellers, writers, researchers, and artists, a substantial gap in representation between materials *about* Inuit peoples versus those *by* Inuit creators remains. The question then becomes: what does Arctic collections development that prioritizes Inuit conceptions and understandings of their homelands look like? How can collections development promote Inuit resilience and resurgence? For one, it will not be driven by more ‘collecting’ with its connotations of extraction without reciprocation or repair. It will be driven by the second word: ‘development’, in the sense of the creation of meaningful relationships with Inuit communities and organizations themselves. Cree and Métis librarian Jessie Loyer writes of ‘disrupting the singular, white man’s joy that shaped collections’: Tyrrell and Wilson are but two examples of many such men whose perspectives are well represented at the Fisher Library.²² While this essay surfaces their collecting legacies, the work ahead is not in rehearsing their stories yet again, but using what we know about them and the stories of their collecting provenance to reunite these materials in whatever form required to their original homes. This will mean reactivating these collections in new ways that ‘nurture . . . the collection’s extended family’ and reconnect them with ‘their living communities’ as Loyer suggests.²³ Doing so with colonial sources like travel narratives can be challenging, though there are numerous opportunities to read against the grain, as Mark A. Cheetham has done via locating an Inuit map situated within a British admiralty chart published in 1850, and as several of the essays in the *Arctic Fever* catalogue also do, especially those coauthored by Deborah Kigjugalik Webster and Carol Payne and by Claudio Aporta and John

MacDonald.²⁴ As the Fisher Library undertakes a project to reorganize and recontextualize the Joseph Burr Tyrrell papers at Fisher, we seek to recentre Tyrrell's Inuit, Cree, and Anishinaabe informers, many of whom made maps and shared their knowledge with him. Ensuring that the relatives of Tyrrell's collaborators have access to the stories and knowledge that we steward means that this multi-generational enterprise can persist with renewed purpose, supporting the 'past, present, and future of Indigeneity...a timeline that is not a line at all'.²⁵

1 For example, a 1792 proclamation by John Graves Simcoe, *A Proclamation, to Such as Are Desirous to Settle on the Lands of the Crown in the Province of Upper Canada*, printed in Quebec by Samuel Neilson.

2 Robert MacDonald, “Challenges and Accomplishments: A Celebration of the Arctic Institute of North America,” *Arctic* 58, no. 4 (December 2005): 440.

3 *Ibid.*, 441.

4 Nora T. Corley, “Marie Tremaine: 1902–1984,” *Arctic* 38, no. 2 (June 1985): 166.

5 *Arctic Bibliography* (Washington: Department of Defence, 1953), [i].

6 The purchase of Rupert’s Land from the Hudson’s Bay Company in 1869–1870 presumably gave the Geological Survey of Canada a perceived right to survey these lands, though the Canadian government had no legal sovereignty over the region Tyrrell visited until the sequence of ‘Numbered Treaties’ of 1899 (Treaty 8), 1906 (Treaty 10), and 1908 (Treaty 5).

7 “1997 Inductee: Joseph Burr Tyrrell,” Canadian Mining Hall of Fame, accessed September 30, 2024, <https://mininghalloffame.ca/joseph-burr-tyrrell/>.

8 See Thomas Fisher Rare Book Library manuscript collection 26, Joseph Burr Tyrrell papers, <https://discoverarchives.library.utoronto.ca/index.php/joseph-burr-tyrrell-papers>.

9 *The Holy Bible* (Newcastle-upon-Tyne: J. Thompson, 1806–1809).

10 An exhibition dedicated to Tyrrell (*J.B. Tyrrell: Explorer and Adventurer; the Geological Survey Years, 1881–1898*) was curated by Katharine Martyn in 1993.

11 Wilson’s contribution was an article for *The Beaver* titled “New Light on Hearne” published in the June 1949 issue, and an entry in the unpublished *Encyclopedia Arctica* (See Dartmouth College Library, *Encyclopedia Arctica* 15: *Biographies*, “Samuel Hearne,” <https://collections.dartmouth.edu/arctica-beta/html/EA15-34.html>).

12 Wilson noted that Wordie was an ‘astute businessman’ in relation to the collecting of Arctic books, implying that he was active in their sale and resale. J. Tuzo Wilson, “Chapter 11: Cambridge 1930–32,” B1993-0050, box 50, file 32, page 12, John Tuzo Wilson fonds, University of Toronto Archives and Records Management Services, University of Toronto Libraries.

13 J. Tuzo Wilson, unpublished memoirs, page 125, private collection of Susan Wilson.

14 *Ibid.*

15 Susan Wilson, phone call with author, October 10, 2024.

16 Nick Eyles, *Tuzo: The Unlikely Revolutionary of Plate Tectonics* (Toronto: Aevo University of Toronto Press, 2022), 123.

17 *Ibid.*, 125.

18 “1997 Inductee, Joseph Burr Tyrrell.”

19 Eyles, 125.

20 Marie Tremaine, “Introduction,” in *Arctic Bibliography* (Washington: Department of Defence, 1953), 7.

21 Please see Maria Nordval’s article in this catalogue.

22 Jessie Loyer, “Collections Are Our Relatives: Disrupting the Singular, White Man’s Joy That Shaped Collections,” in *The Collector and the Collected: Decolonizing Area Studies Librarianship*, ed. Megan Browndorf, Erin Pappas, and Anna Arays (Sacramento: Library Juice Press, 2021), 27.

23 *Ibid.*, 38.

24 Mark A. Cheetham, “Monumental Ephemera: British Sculpture in the Arctic, Icebergs in London, an Inuit Map,” *Art History* 47, no. 2 (April 2024): 389–92, doi:10.1093/arthis/ulae019.

25 Loyer, 40.